SIX

Count Forwards

NELL · DAY 23,228 · TUESDAY 19 MAY 2026

THE EMAIL CAME on a Tuesday morning, from a reader who signed off with an initial and an apology.

Sorry if this is a stupid question, it said, *but what did you mean by the note in the source? The one at the bottom of your second post?*

I read it twice and then I read it a third time, because I didn't understand any of the words in the order they came. The source. A note. The bottom of my second post, which I had written myself, at the kitchen table, in my socks, and which I could have recited to you.

I wrote back and asked what she meant. She sent me a screenshot.

I hadn't known that web pages had a source: that underneath the words you see, there's a second layer of words you don't, instructions to the machine about fonts and spacing and where the pictures go. I had to look it up while she waited. And there, at the bottom of my second post, in the part of the page nobody is meant to read, someone had left a line:

3062 days out. 22,8xx days in. still counting.

I hadn't written it. I didn't know how to write it. I sat at the kitchen table with my laptop and my cooling tea and that line, and the flat was very quiet, and I became aware, in a way I hadn't been for years, of the sound of my own breathing.

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THE BLOGGING PLATFORM keeps a history of every change. I'd never looked at it. Why would you? It's like checking the guest book in your own house.

The line had been added at **03:12** on the night I put up my second post: the night after the logs and the soft brown box, the night I'd posted at a quarter to midnight and gone to bed and slept, for once. It had been added by someone who'd logged in with my username and my password.

Three and a half weeks. It had sat there for three and a half weeks under my own words, and hundreds of people had read past it, and so had I.

I changed my password. Then I changed every password I've ever had, which took most of the afternoon and taught me how many things I'd signed up for in the last decade and forgotten. I switched on every security setting the platform offered, including two I still don't understand. Then I sat very still for a while.

Danny came round after his shift. He read the screenshot standing up, still in his jacket, and his face did the thing.

"You'll report it," he said.

"It's probably just—"

"You'll report it." He had the look he used to give managers who said the pension scheme was *fine*. "Someone got into your house, Nell. It doesn't matter that the house is a website. You report it, and you get a number, and then there's a piece of paper that says it happened."

So I reported it. A patient woman on a non-emergency line took the details, gave me a reference number, and told me kindly that it

was very unlikely anything would come of it. I wrote the number on the back of an envelope and stuck it to the fridge, where it sat like a fridge magnet from a holiday I didn't remember taking.

"Probably a bored kid," I said to Danny, "with a program that guesses passwords."

He didn't answer. He didn't need to.

* * *

THE LETTER CAME on the Saturday.

I almost didn't notice it. It was in among the usual: a pizza menu, a charity bag, something from the council about bins. A plain white envelope, second-class stamp, the postmark smudged into a grey thumbprint. My full name and my address, typed.

My full name: not *Nell*, which @longweather_ had already picked up, but all of it. And my **home** address. Which has never been on the blog, or on anything of mine that I could find, and I looked, that evening, for a long time.

Inside was one sheet of paper, folded twice. It had been typed on a real typewriter: under the kitchen light you could see where each key had bitten into the page, the capitals pressed deeper than the full stops. Across the top ran a thin band of grey, the colour of a sky that hasn't decided whether to rain. There was no other letterhead, no sender's address, no date.

I'm going to set it down exactly as it is. I've read it more times than I've read anything, including my redundancy letter, and that's saying something.

MS OKAFOR-REYES.

YOU COUNTED BACKWARDS. GOOD. NOW COUNT FORWARDS.

3062 DAYS OUT. THAT WAS THE MACHINE LEAVING HARROWGATE.

22861 DAYS IN. THAT WAS THE MACHINE ARRIVING AT YOUR DESK.

THE WEIGHT WAS ALWAYS THE SAME. SEE ENCLOSED.

I AM SORRY ABOUT YOUR WEBSITE. YOUR PASSWORD WAS YOUR FATHERS BIRTHDAY. YOU SHOULD CHANGE IT. YOU SHOULD ALSO ASK WHY I KNOW IT.

DO NOT BLAME ANYONE YOU CAN SEE FROM YOUR WINDOW. THAT IS WHAT THEY WANT.

WHEN YOU ARE READY THE DOOR IS GREY.

It wasn't signed. At the foot of the page there was a small drawing in black ink of a chair: a plain wooden kitchen chair, the kind every family I grew up with had four of, slightly mismatched. Through it, one clean line.

Yes. My password had been my father's birthday. I know. He'd have been disappointed in me, though not surprised.

* * *

DAY 0 WAS the fourteenth of October, 1962. Count forwards 22,861 days.

I didn't need a spreadsheet. I knew before I got there. I did it anyway, by hand, on the back of the council letter about bins, because that's who I am.

Saturday, 17 May 2025.

The croissants. The man with the lanyard and the clicker. Nine of us round a boardroom table in weekend clothes, and the amber dots beginning to move across the map, and the lorry leaving the northern depot by a road I'd never have chosen. *It's live. As of this morning.*

22861 DAYS IN. THAT WAS THE MACHINE ARRIVING AT YOUR DESK.

Somebody had put the teletype leaving that house in 1971 and the system that replaced me on the same line of arithmetic, fifty-four years apart, like two entries in the same ledger. And somebody had known the date of my redundancy briefing well enough

to count to it.

I thought about the previous Sunday: Danny and the chips, the seventeenth of May, a year to the day. Neither of us had said it out loud. I'd thought it was a private anniversary. I'd thought I was the only one keeping count.

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THERE WERE TWO photocopies in the envelope, folded inside the letter.

The first was the 1971 manifest, but not the copy I'd found. Mine was the office copy; Len had as good as told me so. This one had come from the other end: the copy that travelled with the machine, signed for in a small, cramped hand, *recd. Ashby Tst.* Same consignment, same date that wasn't a date, the same purple stamp pressed harder, as if whoever held it had been in a temper that day. And on this copy, the weight box wasn't crossed through. Someone at the far end had weighed it in and written it down:

144 LB.

The second was newer. A Coyle's goods-in note, printed, from May last year, for one server cabinet delivered to the comms room at head office: the local box the new routing system ran through. I'd walked past that cabinet a hundred times. We used to joke about it: the grey box in the comms room was our replacement, we said, back when it was something you could joke about. Signed, dated, and weighed.

144 LB.

I rang Danny. I read him the numbers. There was a pause on the line, and I could hear the warehouse behind him, a beeping forklift, someone shouting a bay number.

"That's about what a small rack cabinet weighs," he said. "And those old teletypes weren't light. Heavy office kit is heavy office kit, Nell."

He was right. A hundred and forty-four pounds is a perfectly ordinary weight for a heavy box. A coincidence is nothing. I'd seen a

thousand coincidences in eleven years of freight, and most of them were just the world being a smaller place than it looks.

But someone had found both of those pieces of paper, fifty-four years apart. Someone had copied them, folded them into a plain envelope, and posted them to an address I'd never given any of my readers, so that I'd notice.

The coincidence might be nothing. The noticing was arranged.

* * *

AFTER I PUT the phone down, I went to the window.

I don't know why. The letter had told me to, I suppose, in its way. *Do not blame anyone you can see from your window.* I'd read it as a warning. Standing there, I started to read it as an instruction to look.

It was a Saturday afternoon, and the street was doing what streets do. Across the road Graham was out on his step, watering the hanging basket he's prouder of than anything else in his life, a ridiculous explosion of fuchsias that drips on the postman. He has a grey front door. I'd never noticed the colour of it before.

Further down, the young mother from the food bank queue was wrestling her pushchair over the kerb, the one that was too high for pushchairs and had been reported to the council, by my count, four times. Two lads I half recognised from the estate were sitting on the low wall outside the shop, sharing a bag of something, laughing at a phone. The man from the flats with the dog was walking the dog. At the end of the road, if I leaned, I could see the corner of the block with the plywood window, and I knew without seeing it that the rainbow was still taped to the glass.

Ordinary people. Tired people. People who had been told, every day, by every screen they owned, which of the others to be afraid of.

Do not blame anyone you can see from your window. That is what they want.

I'd heard that sentence before. Danny, in my kitchen, a week ago, with chips going cold on the counter: *Don't let anyone tell you it's the people down your street.*

And for one second, at that window, the thought came in the way cold comes under a door. Danny knew where I lived. Danny had known my father's birthday for nearly thirty years; he'd eaten half the cake at most of them. Danny had said it first.

I said "No," out loud, to the empty flat, the way you'd tell a dog to get down.

I didn't know what to do with any of it. I still don't, entirely. But I stood at the window until Graham went in and the street lights came on, and I didn't blame anyone. It turned out to be harder work than I'd expected.

* * *

You should also ask why I know it.

So I asked. Sitting at the kitchen table, with the letter in front of me and the grey band catching the light, I asked myself all the questions I'd been carefully not asking for a month.

My father worked in the head office at Coyle's for thirty years, from 1979 until he retired. He started as a clerk and became a senior clerk, and then he became something there wasn't a job title for: the man who knew where everything was. If you wanted a document from any year, any depot, any driver, you asked Emmanuel, and he took off his reading glasses and told you the shelf. It's how I got my interview there: the director who hired me said, *If you're half as tidy as your father, we'll manage.*

He was kind. He was quiet. He did the cryptic crossword every evening in pen, which he said was the only arrogant thing about him, and he never kept a secret in his life that I knew of.

That I knew of.

Len had said the office would ring the drivers at home, the night before one of those runs. No job sheet in the cab. Collect, deliver, cash at the far end from a man with a face that didn't stick.

The office would ring.

I got up. I didn't decide to. I found myself standing at the shelf, with my hand on my father's crossword dictionary, the one with the spine broken in three places from forty years of opening at the same letters.

I took it down. It fell open on its own, the way old books do, at the pages he'd used most, and there in the margins, in his small, upright pencil, were his marks: a tick here, a dot there, a word underlined, a number written very small beside a clue I'd never see.

I could have read them. They were right there. A man's private notes, beside the words he'd looked up most in forty years, and I'm a reconciler: reading what other people wrote in the margins is the thing I'm for.

I closed it. I put it back on the shelf with the spine facing out, the way he always had.

Some things you count. And some things you leave on the shelf, so that for one more night the man who knew where everything was is still just your father, finishing the crossword, in pen.